

for the Environment—at COP26 in Glasgow seemed to provide an alternate development pathway. It calls for sustainable lifestyles rooted in responsible consumption, ecological mindfulness, and alignment with nature's regenerative capacities. In the process, LiFE intersects with all the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The approach does not discard growth ambitions; rather, it asks nations and individuals alike to realign their paths to progress in harmony with nature.

Many would identify LiFE with the occidental degrowth philosophy, though they are fundamentally different. Degrowth advocates a deliberate slowdown of economic activity, emphasising ecological balance, social justice, and redistribution.

Though it resonates with LiFE's emphasis on reconfiguring our metabolic relationship with nature, it is more radical in tone and scope from the perspective of advocating retraction from the present ways of living.

Degrowth often overlooks the socio-economic realities of the Global South. In regions where poverty, informality, and underdevelopment persist, a hard shift to degrowth without systemic safety nets could be destabilising, as evidenced by Sri Lanka. In such contexts, LiFE allows each country and community to define their paths, provided they align their lifestyles with ecological limits.

All three paradigms—SDGs, LiFE, and degrowth—converge on a critical idea: the need to conserve

biodiversity, protect natural ecosystems, and transition to renewable energy.

Yet degrowth rejects the very notion of "sustainable development," arguing that any pursuit of economic growth, even when paired with conservation, remains fundamentally flawed. In contrast, LiFE accommodates aspirations and diversity of pathways, suggesting a more inclusive and less doctrinaire framework. India's challenge, therefore, is not to choose between growth and degrowth, but to transcend this binary altogether. India must define a developmental pathway that acknowledges its need to grow to achieve its Viksit Bharat by 2047 goal, but not in the business-as-usual mode through natural capital degradation and widening inequality.

The philosophy of inclusive wealth needs to be embraced at a more micro-level, including the corporate sector. These four forms of capital are embedded in the various delineations of sustainability, including the SDGs. Empirical analysis shows that firms with better compliance with ESG parameters have revealed better bottom lines as compared to others. India also needs to strengthen its climate adaptation financing, a sector largely ignored by financial institutions. This will require creating a market for adaptation with a properly exhibited RoI for adaptation projects for the financial institutions, mandating a substantial portion of the CSR expenditures to get into adaptation financing, and tapping philanthropic financing.

In other words, India's climate-resilient development architecture needs growth strategies and an aggressive push to reduce income and social inequality. **BT**

ILLUSTRATION BY **RAJ VERMA**

